

« BEFORE

The US had conducted bombing strikes on targets in the North from the mid-1960s onward.

LIMITED IMPACT

The US bombing of the North at first mainly targeted **military and naval** installations in the Hanoi and Haiphong areas. This strategy had little impact on the North Vietnamese war effort and later bombing campaigns extended the targets from bridges, roads, and railroads to **whole areas** to demoralize the population. However, this also proved ineffective.



CELEBRATING RESISTANCE AGAINST US BOMBING

Early in 1972, the US had begun planning a renewed bombing campaign of North Vietnam, and the Spring Offensive of April reinforced a determination to disrupt supply lines from the North. Advances in aerial bombing technology made the precise targeting of military objectives without excessive collateral damage a real possibility.

Precision attack

The planning for the operation that would be named Linebacker I was well underway by March. The Air Force and Navy had assembled significant reinforcements of aircraft and ships from South Korea, Taiwan, Japan, and the United States.

The first day of the operation was May 10, 1972, when strike formations of Navy and Marine aircraft flew into North Vietnam from Yankee Station in the Tonkin Gulf, and Air Force planes from US bases in Thailand flew in along the Mekong River. Over the ensuing days and weeks, the Americans destroyed bridges, railroad facilities, roads, and tunnels. One of the big successes occurred on May 13, when US aircraft attacked the notorious and highly defended Thanh Hoa Bridge, a key conduit for supplies down the panhandle of North Vietnam. During Rolling Thunder the bridge had been bombed many times but never destroyed. The strike, with two dozen laser-guided bombs, demolished the western